

First 90 Days: A Microlearning Series for New Managers

Design Document

Format: Three-part microlearning series (Articulate Rise 360) **Audience:** Newly promoted first-time managers, weeks 1 through 13 **Design models:** ADDIE (process), Mager's ABCD (objectives), Bloom's Taxonomy (cognitive sequencing), Gagné's Nine Events (module architecture)

Why this document exists

Most portfolio pieces show the finished course. This one shows the reasoning underneath it: why each objective is written the way it is, why the scenarios are structured the way they are, and what I changed after reviewing my own draft. Instructional design is a series of defensible decisions, and the decisions are the part worth reading.

Phase 1: Analysis

The performance gap

Current state. Newly promoted managers step into their first leadership role having been selected for individual-contributor excellence, not for management capability. In their first 90 days they typically default to peer-era habits: they leave role expectations implicit, postpone or soften corrective feedback until issues have compounded, and communicate reactively rather than establishing predictable rhythms with their team.

Desired state. By the end of their first 90 days, new managers can set and confirm clear role expectations, conduct structured feedback conversations that address performance directly while preserving the relationship, and maintain team communication cadences that build trust and surface problems early.

Gap and impact. The distance between these states shows up as unclear expectations driving missed or misaligned deliverables, avoided feedback allowing performance and behavioral issues to entrench, and ad-hoc communication eroding team clarity and engagement. Left unaddressed, a poorly navigated first 90 days is a leading contributor to early direct-report disengagement and regrettable attrition, which makes it the costliest window in the manager-team relationship to get wrong.

Scope decision: sector-neutral by design

I built this series for a composite organization rather than a specific industry. The three skills it targets (setting expectations, giving feedback, managing communication rhythms) transfer across sectors with almost no modification to the underlying content. What changes by sector is the vignette wrapper, and I've noted the localization points for each module in the rationale sections below. A sector-neutral core with documented reskin points is more useful than three sector-locked versions of the same instruction.

Phase 2: Design

The shared architecture

Rather than deriving a new structure for each module, I built one instructional architecture on Gagné's Nine Events and applied it across all three. This is a deliberate choice: a learner moving between modules should not have to re-learn how the course works, and consistent structure lets them spend that attention on content instead.

#	Gagné's Event	How it appears in every module
1	Gain attention	A short, recognizable first-90-days vignette specific to the module's problem
2	Inform objectives	Plain-language restatement of the terminal objective
3	Recall prior knowledge	A prompt connecting to the learner's own experience of being managed
4	Present content	The core framework taught (What/When/What-if, SBI, channel matching)
5	Provide learning guidance	A narrated worked example
6	Elicit performance	Branching scenario 1 (ungraded practice)
7	Provide feedback	Branch-specific coaching embedded in the scenario outcomes
8	Assess performance	A drag-and-drop knowledge check plus branching scenario 2 (graded)
9	Enhance retention and transfer	A downloadable job aid tied to a real next-step application

This architecture is also why each module contains exactly two branching scenarios rather than an arbitrary number: the scenarios *are* events 6 and 8. The assessment strategy is built into the instructional sequence rather than bolted on after it.

The difficulty arc

Cognitive demand climbs deliberately across the series:

- **Module 1** sits at Bloom's **Apply**. The learner runs one conversation.
- **Module 2** pushes into **Create**. The learner constructs a feedback script under a framework.
- **Module 3** lands at **Create** at a higher grain size. The learner designs an ongoing system.

This mirrors how the first-90-days problem actually compounds: one conversation becomes a harder conversation becomes a standing rhythm. The sequencing is the argument that these are three parts of one program rather than three separate lessons.

Module 1: Setting Expectations

Terminal objective (Mager's ABCD)

- **Audience:** The new manager
- **Behavior:** will conduct a documented expectations-setting conversation that identifies at least three measurable performance expectations and confirms mutual understanding
- **Condition:** given a new-hire onboarding scenario and a role-expectations template
- **Degree:** meeting all criteria on the expectations-conversation checklist

Enabling objectives

1. (*Bloom's: Analyze*) Given five example expectation statements, the manager will distinguish vague from measurable statements, correctly classifying at least four of five.

2. (*Bloom's: Evaluate*) Given a scenario where a direct report pushes back on an expectation as unrealistic, the manager will select a response that clarifies the expectation while inviting dialogue, avoiding both capitulation and rigidity.

Core framework taught: every workable expectation names a **What** (the specific outcome), a **When** (a real deadline or response time), and a **What-if** (how the person flags a problem early).

Module 2: Feedback Conversations

Terminal objective (Mager's ABCD)

- **Audience:** The new manager
- **Behavior:** will deliver a feedback conversation, structured around Situation-Behavior-Impact, that addresses a specific behavior, states its impact, and proposes a next step
- **Condition:** given a documented performance issue and the SBI framework
- **Degree:** without generalizing to character or using vague language, as judged against a feedback-quality rubric

Enabling objectives

1. (*Bloom's: Analyze*) Given five sample feedback statements, the manager will classify each as behavior-focused or character-focused, correctly identifying at least four of five.
2. (*Bloom's: Evaluate*) Given a scenario where a direct report reacts defensively, the manager will select responses that maintain the SBI structure and keep the conversation on track, avoiding escalation or backpedaling.

Core framework taught: Situation, Behavior, Impact. Anchor the moment, describe what was observably done, name the effect.

Module 3: Team Communication

Terminal objective (Mager's ABCD)

- **Audience:** The new manager
- **Behavior:** will design a 90-day team communication plan specifying at least three distinct channels or rhythms matched to appropriate purposes
- **Condition:** given a team-communication case scenario
- **Degree:** meeting the criteria on the communication-plan rubric

Enabling objectives

1. (*Bloom's: Apply*) Given a set of team scenarios (urgent issue, sensitive personnel matter, routine update), the manager will match each to the most appropriate communication channel, correctly matching at least four of five.
2. (*Bloom's: Evaluate*) Given a scenario depicting a communication breakdown, the manager will select the response that repairs trust and adjusts the communication rhythm going forward.

Core framework taught: match channel to message by asking two questions, how urgent and how sensitive, with the override rule that sensitive always goes private and live.

Phase 3: Development

Scenario design principles

Three rules governed every branching scenario in the series.

1. The wrong answers are plausible, not absurd. Each decision point offers a strong response, an under-response (capitulate, soften, backpedal), and an over-response (rigid, harsh, over-specified). The under-response is always the tempting one, because avoidance is what new managers actually reach for under discomfort. A learner who recognizes their own instinct in a weak branch is learning something; a learner choosing between one good option and two obviously stupid ones is not.

2. Consequences are shown, not announced. Every branch plays out what the other person does or says next, before the coaching note appears. The instructional weight sits in seeing the outcome, not in being told the answer was wrong.

3. The scenarios come from lived leadership problems. I spent nearly two decades in music education leading programs, teaching sections, and running multi-cohort ensembles, and each module's scenarios are rooted in a specific recurring problem from that work:

- **Module 1** comes from telling someone who was a peer yesterday exactly when sectionals start and what "come prepared" actually means. Vagueness does not spare anyone's feelings; it relocates the conflict to a worse moment later.
- **Module 2** comes from telling a student their entrance in measure 32 was late without it becoming "you're careless." The behavior is fixable. The character verdict just makes them defensive and tells them nothing to do differently.
- **Module 3** comes from changing a rehearsal plan and posting it without telling the two people whose schedules it wrecked. The change was not the problem. The way they found out was.

The six scenarios

Each scenario below is the complete branching structure as built: setup, three options, the outcome each produces, and the coaching feedback the learner receives.

Module 1, Scenario 1: The Inbox

Ungraded practice. Serves enabling objective 1 (Analyze).

Setup. Your team just took over the shared client-request inbox, and you're handing day-to-day ownership to Tomás. He's reliable and wants to do it well, but "own the inbox" could mean a dozen different things. You're setting the expectation for the first time.

Decision point: how do you set the expectation?

Option A (vague). "Just keep an eye on the inbox and stay on top of it. Make sure clients don't fall through the cracks." - *Outcome:* Tomás checks it a few times a day when he remembers. A client waits two days for a reply, and when you ask, Tomás says, "I was staying on top of it, I just hadn't gotten to that one yet." Nothing he did actually contradicts what you asked for. - *Coaching:* "Stay on top of it" sounds like a standard, but it names no timeframe and no definition of "handled." Tomás filled the gap with his own reasonable guess, which is all a vague expectation ever gets you.

Option B (measurable). "Acknowledge every new request within four business hours, even if it's just to say you've got it and when they'll hear back. Log each one in the tracker so nothing gets lost. And if something comes in that you're not sure how to answer, flag it to me the same day rather than sitting on it." - *Outcome:* Tomás knows exactly what "handled" means and what to do when he's stuck. Clients get a fast acknowledgment, the tracker stays current, and the one request he can't answer himself lands on your desk the same afternoon. - *Coaching:* A workable expectation names the What (acknowledge and log), the When (within four business hours), and the What-if (flag anything you can't answer the same day). Notice this isn't a deadline-and-deliverable task like a monthly report; "measurable" had to be built out of a response time and a clear definition of done, not a date on the calendar.

Option C (over-specified). You write out a script for every kind of request, dictate the exact wording of each reply, and tell Tomás to run anything not covered by the scripts past you first. - *Outcome:* Tomás follows the scripts, but the moment a client asks something slightly off-script he stops and waits for you, and simple requests start backing up in your own inbox. - *Coaching:* Measurable isn't the same as scripted. You've defined the outcome so tightly there's no room for judgment, and

turned yourself into the bottleneck you were trying to delegate around. Set the standard and the guardrails; trust Tomás inside them.

Module 1, Scenario 2: The Pushback

Graded. Serves enabling objective 2 (Evaluate).

Setup. You've told Marcus that client emails should get a response within one business day, even if the response is just "got it, I'm on it." Marcus frowns: "Honestly, that's not realistic with everything else on my plate."

Decision point: how do you respond?

Option A (capitulate). "Okay, fair enough. Just do your best and get to them when you can." - *Outcome:* The expectation quietly dies. Two weeks later a client complains they went three days without hearing back, and Marcus points out, reasonably, that you told him to use his judgment. - *Coaching:* Dropping the expectation the second it's questioned teaches your team that expectations are negotiable by objection. You also never found out why it felt unrealistic, which might have been a real problem worth solving.

Option B (clarify and hold). "Tell me what's making a one-day turnaround feel tight. I want to understand the workload before we lock anything in." - *Outcome:* Marcus explains he's also covering the front desk two afternoons a week, which eats his response time. The real issue is capacity, not the standard. You can now solve the actual problem, maybe by shifting the desk coverage, and keep the response-time expectation intact. - *Coaching:* You held the expectation and opened the door at the same time. Pushback is often information in disguise. The move is to stay curious about the constraint without abandoning the standard before you understand it.

Option C (rigid). "It's the standard here. Everyone manages it, so I need you to as well. That's just the expectation." - *Outcome:* Marcus says "fine" and complies, but the front-desk conflict you never heard about keeps causing near-misses. He stops raising concerns with you. - *Coaching:* You won the moment and lost the information. Standing firm on a standard is fine. Doing it without hearing the constraint means you're now managing a problem you can't see.

Module 2, Scenario 1: The Client Email

Ungraded practice. Serves enabling objective 1 (Analyze).

Setup. Renee sent two client emails this week that went out with the wrong Q3 figures. The client caught the second one and wrote back asking which numbers were actually right. Renee is capable and usually careful, but you need to address it before it happens again.

Decision point: how do you open the conversation?

Option A (character). "You've been getting kind of careless with the client stuff lately. I need you to be more detail-oriented." - *Outcome:* Renee's face closes. "I'm not careless. I've just had a lot on my plate this week." Now you're arguing about whether Renee is a careful person instead of about two specific emails. - *Coaching:* "Careless" is a judgment about who Renee is, and people defend that hard. You also handed her nothing to act on, because you didn't point to anything she actually did.

Option B (Situation-Behavior-Impact). "The last two client emails went out with the wrong Q3 numbers, and the client wrote back asking us to confirm which figures were right. It put us in the spot of having to walk it back." - *Outcome:* Renee winces. "You're right, I was rushing both of those. Let me build in a check before anything goes to the client." The conversation is now about a specific, fixable habit. - *Coaching:* Situation, behavior, impact, and nothing to defend against, because you described the emails and their effect, not Renee's character. She can picture exactly what to change.

Option C (over-softened). "Hey, no big deal at all, but maybe just try to be a little more careful with the client emails? You're doing great otherwise." - *Outcome:* Renee says "yeah, for sure" and can't tell whether you've flagged a real problem or made small talk. The next email goes out unchecked. - *Coaching:* You softened it until the signal disappeared. "Be more careful" isn't a behavior she can act on, and pairing it with "no big deal" tells her it isn't worth changing. Clear and kind can coexist; this was neither.

Module 2, Scenario 2: The Deflection

Graded. Serves enabling objective 2 (Evaluate).

Setup. You've given Sam clear, behavior-focused feedback: two client handoffs got missed last week, and both clients were left waiting. Sam responds immediately: "Well, if the handoff process weren't such a mess, this wouldn't keep happening. It's not on me."

Decision point: how do you respond?

Option A (backpedal). “You know what, you’re right, the process is a disaster. Forget I brought it up, let’s just fix the process.” - *Outcome:* The feedback evaporates. The process does have problems, but so does Sam’s ownership, and you just signaled the second one doesn’t count. - *Coaching:* A real process problem doesn’t erase a missed handoff; both can be true. By dropping your point the moment Sam pushed, you taught them that deflection works.

Option B (acknowledge and hold). “The process might genuinely need fixing, and I want to hear where it’s breaking down. Let’s put time on that this week. And in the meantime, these handoffs still have to happen. Can we do both?” - *Outcome:* Sam exhales. “Yeah. Okay. The problem’s really the tracking sheet; it doesn’t flag when something’s assigned to me.” Now you have the ownership and the process fix. - *Coaching:* The word is “and,” not “but.” You validated the real constraint without letting it become a reason the standard doesn’t apply. Both things stay on the table.

Option C (escalate). “I don’t want to hear excuses. The handoffs are your job. Just do them.” - *Outcome:* Sam goes flat: “Fine.” They stop mentioning the tracking-sheet problem, which keeps causing misses for the whole team, not just Sam. - *Coaching:* You turned feedback into a standoff. Even when someone’s deflecting, there’s often a real issue underneath. Shut it down and you lose it, along with Sam’s willingness to flag the next one.

Module 3, Scenario 1: The Right Channel

Ungraded practice. Serves enabling objective 1 (Apply).

Setup. Three things hit your desk in one morning: a server outage threatening a client demo in an hour, a routine update about new expense codes, and a team member, Alex, whose work has slipped noticeably for two weeks. You’ve heard secondhand that something’s going on at home. You want to check in.

Decision point: how do you reach out to Alex about the slip?

Option A (async chat). You send Alex a direct message: “Hey, noticed your output’s been down the last couple weeks and a few things have slipped. Everything okay? Let me know what’s going on.” - *Outcome:* Alex reads it between tasks, feels suddenly exposed, and writes back “all good, sorry, will fix it.” You’ve closed a door you meant to open. - *Coaching:* Sensitive and personal belongs in a live, private conversation. In text, “everything okay?” reads as a paper trail about performance, not a human checking in. The channel undercut the intent.

Option B (private, real-time). You catch Alex and ask for a few minutes somewhere private, then open with, “I wanted to check in. I’ve noticed the last couple of weeks have felt different, and I’m not here to pile on. How are you doing?” - *Outcome:* Alex is quiet for a second, then tells you their kid’s been in and out of the doctor. You can now actually help, by adjusting deadlines or pointing to leave options, instead of just flagging a problem. - *Coaching:* Channel matched the sensitivity: private, live, and framed as concern rather than correction. The medium is part of the message.

Option C (team setting). You raise it at the daily stand-up: “Alex, your numbers have been low lately, what’s going on there?” - *Outcome:* Alex freezes in front of everyone. Whatever trust you had takes a real hit, and the rest of the team quietly notes that struggles get aired in public here. - *Coaching:* Never a personal or sensitive matter in front of the group. You didn’t just mishandle one conversation; you told the whole team what it’s like to have a hard week on your watch.

Module 3, Scenario 2: The Blindside

Graded. Serves enabling objective 2 (Evaluate).

Setup. You decided to move the weekly team meeting from Thursday to Monday, and sent an updated calendar invite. Rae, who runs a workstream that depends on the old Thursday timing for a client deliverable, finds out only when the invite pops up. She catches you after: “That’s going to be a problem for the Delgado account. Would’ve been nice to be asked.”

Decision point: how do you respond?

Option A (defensive). “It’s just a meeting time. We can’t run every scheduling decision by everybody, it’s not that big a deal.” - *Outcome:* Rae says “sure, okay” and stops flagging the Delgado conflict, which surfaces two weeks later as a missed client date. Rae also stops giving you early warning on other things. - *Coaching:* The meeting time isn’t the point; being blindsided is. By defending the decision instead of hearing the impact, you confirmed that raising a concern with you isn’t worth the effort.

Option B (repair and adjust the system). “You’re right, I should’ve checked with you before moving it, especially with Delgado riding on that timing. Let’s find a slot that doesn’t blow up your deliverable. And going forward, I’ll run schedule changes past the people they actually affect before they go out.” - *Outcome:* Rae relaxes: “That’s all I wanted. Wednesday

afternoon actually works better anyway.” You fixed the immediate conflict and the pattern that caused it. - *Coaching*: You repaired the moment and the rhythm. Naming the miss costs you nothing and buys back trust; changing the process is what stops it recurring.

Option C (over-apologize, no change). “Oh gosh, I’m so sorry, that was thoughtless of me, I feel terrible about it.” But you leave the meeting on Monday and change nothing about how you’ll make the next decision. - *Outcome*: Rae accepts the apology, but the Delgado conflict is still unsolved, and the next unilateral change lands the same way. The apology starts to feel like a reflex. - *Coaching*: An apology without a changed process just resets the same trap. Feeling bad isn’t the repair. Adjusting the deliverable and the decision-making habit is.

The storyboard

Each module is one Rise lesson following the same ten-block sequence. Block names carry the Gagné event they serve.

Module 1: Setting Expectations

Block	On-screen text	Layout
1.0 Cover	Setting Expectations. Module 1 of 3: Your First 90 Days as a Manager. The clearest thing you can do for your team in week one is tell them exactly what “good” looks like.	Cover (text on image)
1.1 The Handoff (Event 1)	Priya is taking over the monthly reconciliation report from a teammate who just left. She’s sharp and eager, but she’s never owned this before. You have thirty seconds in the hallway to set her up for it. What do you actually say?	Statement / text on image
1.2 What You’ll Be Able to Do (Event 2)	By the end of this module, you’ll be able to run an expectations conversation that names the three things every clear expectation needs: the what, the when, and the what-if. You’ll practice turning fuzzy expectations into ones your team can act on, and holding that line when someone pushes back.	Text + image
1.3 Think Back (Event 3)	Think about a time you were handed a task without knowing what “done well” looked like. How long did it take to figure out what your manager actually wanted, and what did that guessing cost you both? Keep that in mind: your team does the same guessing whenever an expectation stays in your head.	Reflection block
1.4 What a Clear Expectation Contains (Event 4)	The What: the specific outcome, not the activity. “A reconciled report with variances flagged,” not “work on the reconciliation.” The When: a real deadline tied to something concrete. “The third business day after month-end,” not “soon after close.” The What-if: the early-warning valve. “If the date is going to be tight, tell me by the first business day.” This is the part most managers skip, and it’s the one that prevents surprises.	Click-to-reveal (accordion or tabs)
1.5 See It Done (Event 5)	Here’s the Priya handoff, done well: “The report’s due the third business day after month-end. I’ll send you last month’s version as a model for the format. And if anything’s ever going to make that date tight, tell me by the first business day so we can adjust.” All three parts are there: the what, the when, and the what-if. A thirty-second conversation that prevents a six-day-late surprise.	Text + image
1.6 Vague or Workable? (Event 8)	Drag each expectation into the right bucket. Workable expectations name a specific outcome and a real deadline; vague ones leave room to guess.	Drag-and-drop sorting

	Items: “Get me the report soon after close.” / “Submit the reconciliation by the third business day, variances flagged.” / “Keep the client updated regularly.” / “Reply to client emails within one business day.” / “Be more proactive with the account.” Buckets: Workable · Vague	
1.7 Scenario: The Inbox (Events 6 and 7)	Practice scenario. You’re handing day-to-day ownership of the shared client-request inbox to Tomás. Choose how you set the expectation.	Scenario block (ungraded)
1.8 Scenario: The Pushback (Event 8)	Graded scenario. You’ve asked Marcus for a one-business-day email turnaround and he says it’s not realistic. Choose your response.	Scenario block (graded)
1.9 Your Takeaway (Event 9)	Before your next expectation conversation, write it out in three parts: What, When, What-if. Download the Expectations Checklist and use it for a real handoff this week.	Text + downloadable attachment

Module 2: Feedback Conversations

Block	On-screen text	Layout
2.0 Cover	Feedback Conversations. Module 2 of 3: Your First 90 Days as a Manager. The feedback you avoid doesn’t disappear; it just gets more expensive.	Cover (text on image)
2.1 The Interruption (Event 1)	Jordan talked over a quieter teammate twice in this morning’s meeting. After the second time, she stopped contributing. You need to say something, but the wrong opening will make Jordan defensive before you’ve made your point. Where do you start?	Statement / text on image
2.2 What You’ll Be Able to Do (Event 2)	By the end of this module, you’ll be able to deliver feedback built on Situation-Behavior-Impact: name what happened, describe the specific behavior, and state its effect, without turning it into a verdict on the person. You’ll also practice holding that structure when the other person gets defensive.	Text + image
2.3 Think Back (Event 3)	Think about a piece of feedback that actually changed how you worked. Odds are it pointed at something you did, not at who you are. Now think about feedback that just stung and changed nothing. The difference is usually the same one: a behavior you can fix versus a label you can only resent.	Reflection block
2.4 The SBI Model (Event 4)	Situation: anchor it in a specific moment. “In the ten o’clock meeting this morning,” not “lately.” Behavior: describe what they observably did. “You cut across Dana twice while she was still talking.” No interpretation, no character read. Impact: state the effect it had. “She didn’t say anything for the rest of the meeting.” This is what makes the behavior worth changing.	Click-to-reveal (tabs or accordion)
2.5 See It Done (Event 5)	Here’s the Jordan conversation with SBI: “In the ten o’clock meeting, you cut across Dana twice while she was still talking. After the second time, she went quiet for the rest of the meeting.” There’s nothing to argue with, because you described what happened, not what it says about Jordan. Compare that to “you were kind of domineering in there,” which starts a debate about Jordan’s character and fixes nothing.	Text + image
2.6 Behavior or Character? (Event 8)	Drag each statement into the right bucket. Only behavior-focused feedback gives someone	Drag-and-drop sorting

	something they can act on. Items: “You interrupted Dana twice this morning.” / “You’re kind of a steamroller.” / “The report came in two days after the deadline.” / “You just don’t care about quality.” / “You didn’t respond to the client for three days.” Buckets: Behavior-focused · Character-focused	
2.7 Scenario: The Client Email (Events 6 and 7)	Practice scenario. Renee sent two client emails with the wrong figures and the client flagged it. Choose how you open the feedback conversation.	Scenario block (ungraded)
2.8 Scenario: The Deflection (Event 8)	Graded scenario. You gave Sam clear feedback about two missed handoffs, and Sam deflects to the broken process. Choose your response.	Scenario block (graded)
2.9 Your Takeaway (Event 9)	Before your next feedback conversation, script the first two sentences with SBI: situation and behavior in sentence one, impact in sentence two. If you can’t name a specific behavior, you’re not ready to have the conversation yet. Download the SBI Prep Card.	Text + downloadable attachment

Module 3: Team Communication

Block	On-screen text	Layout
3.0 Cover	Team Communication. Module 3 of 3: Your First 90 Days as a Manager. How your team finds things out matters as much as what you tell them.	Cover (text on image)
3.1 The Busy Morning (Event 1)	Three things hit your desk in one morning: a server outage before a client demo, a routine expense-code update, and a teammate whose work has quietly slipped for two weeks. Each one needs a different way of reaching people. Send the wrong message the wrong way and you create a second problem on top of the first.	Statement / text on image
3.2 What You’ll Be Able to Do (Event 2)	By the end of this module, you’ll be able to match a message to the right channel based on its urgency and sensitivity, and repair a communication breakdown by fixing both the immediate damage and the habit that caused it.	Text + image
3.3 Think Back (Event 3)	Think about a time you found out about a decision that affected you after it was already made. Not the decision itself, but the way you found out. How did that land? That feeling is what your team gets when a change shows up in a calendar invite instead of a conversation.	Reflection block
3.4 Matching Channel to Message (Event 4)	Private and real-time (a call, a walk, a closed door): for anything sensitive or personal. If it could embarrass someone, it happens here. Group and real-time (a meeting, a quick huddle): for urgent things everyone needs at once, or decisions that need discussion. Async and written (chat, email, a posted update): for routine information that doesn’t need a reaction. Fast and efficient, and exactly wrong for sensitive news.	Click-to-reveal (tabs or accordion)
3.5 See It Done (Event 5)	Back to that busy morning. The server outage is urgent and shared, so it goes to the team channel or a fast huddle. The expense-code update is routine, so async email is perfect. The teammate whose work has slipped is sensitive and personal, so it’s a private, real-time conversation, never a chat message and never in front of the group. Same morning, three channels, each matched to what the message actually is.	Text + image

3.6 Which Channel? (Event 8)	Drag each message to the channel that fits it best. Items: “A system is down and a client demo is in an hour.” / “The new expense codes take effect Monday.” / “A teammate’s performance has slipped and something personal may be going on.” / “A reminder that timesheets are due Friday.” / “A decision that changes one person’s project timeline.” Buckets: Private + real-time · Group + real-time · Async + written	Drag-and-drop sorting
3.7 Scenario: The Right Channel (Events 6 and 7)	Practice scenario. A teammate’s work has slipped and you’ve heard something’s going on at home. Choose how you reach out.	Scenario block (ungraded)
3.8 Scenario: The Blindside (Event 8)	Graded scenario. You moved the team meeting and Rae found out from the calendar invite, with a client deliverable affected. Choose your response.	Scenario block (graded)
3.9 Your Takeaway (Event 9)	Before you send your next team message, ask two questions: how urgent is it, and how sensitive is it? Sensitive always goes private and live. Download the Channel-Match Guide and keep it nearby for your first 90 days.	Text + downloadable attachment

Transfer artifacts: the three job aids

Each module ends with a downloadable one-pager. These are Gagné’s ninth event made concrete: the course ends, but the job aid goes back to the desk with the learner.

1. The Expectations Checklist (Module 1). A fill-in template with three prompts (What, When, What-if), a worked example, and a closing “confirm it landed” step that asks the manager to have the other person say back what they’re taking away. That confirmation step is in the terminal objective, so it had to be in the job aid, but I placed it as a closing move rather than a fourth prompt to keep the three-part structure the module drills.

2. The SBI Prep Card (Module 2). Three fill-in lines for Situation, Behavior, and Impact, plus a side-by-side comparison strip contrasting behavior-focused statements against their character-focused equivalents. The card is designed to be read five minutes before a hard conversation rather than filled out at a desk, so it’s built to be scannable under mild stress.

3. The Channel-Match Guide (Module 3). A two-by-two decision grid crossing urgency against sensitivity, with the override rule (“sensitive always goes private and live”) called out below it. The fourth quadrant, sensitive but not urgent, gets its own cell and a warning against letting it drift, because that’s the quadrant where necessary conversations quietly never happen.

Design revisions

I reviewed the full draft against the instructional architecture before build and found a transfer problem worth documenting.

The problem. In Module 1, the worked example (block 1.5) taught the What/When/What-if framework using Priya’s monthly report. The practice scenario that followed (block 1.7) then asked the learner to set an expectation for Priya’s monthly report. The learner could scroll up two screens and find the exact language. That isn’t eliciting performance, which is what Gagné’s sixth event requires; it’s rewarding recall of a sentence. A capable learner would notice, and would reasonably feel the course was talking down to them.

The fix. I rewrote the practice scenario around a different situation: handing ownership of a shared client-request inbox to a new person. Critically, the new scenario is an *ongoing responsibility* rather than a dated deliverable, so “the third business day after month-end” doesn’t transfer. The learner has to work out what “measurable” means when the task has no deadline, which means building the response-time standard themselves. Priya stays as the taught example; the practice now requires near transfer instead of recognition.

The audit that followed. Finding one instance prompted me to check the other two modules for the same pattern. Module 2 had a milder version of it: the worked example and the practice scenario both used Jordan’s meeting interruption. I rewrote that practice scenario around a different feedback situation (client emails sent with incorrect figures), which also broadened the module’s coverage from a live interpersonal behavior to a written work-product error. Module 3 was already clean, since its worked example covered channel triage across three messages while its practice scenario addressed a single sensitive check-in.

Why this is in the document. The revision is the part of the process that most resembles real instructional design work. A first draft that follows the model correctly at the structural level can still fail at the learner’s experience level, and the only way to catch it is to walk the sequence as a learner rather than as its author.

Evaluation

Formative. The design review described above, conducted against the Gagné architecture before development. Each block was checked for whether it actually performs the event it's assigned to.

Level 1 (Reaction). A short post-module survey on relevance and confidence, with one open-ended prompt asking which scenario felt most like the learner's own situation. That last item is the most useful signal for revising the scenarios.

Level 2 (Learning). Built in. Each module contains a drag-and-drop knowledge check calibrated to its Analyze-level enabling objective, and a graded branching scenario calibrated to its Evaluate-level objective. The four-of-five thresholds in the enabling objectives are the pass criteria.

Level 3 (Behavior). The job aids are the transfer mechanism, and each module's final block assigns a real application ("use it for a real handoff this week"). In a live deployment I would pair this with a 60-day manager check-in reviewing whether documented expectations exist for each direct report and whether one-on-one rhythms have been established, since those are observable without a survey.

Sector localization

The series is sector-neutral by design, and each module has a different localization profile.

Module 1 localizes through the vignette only. Swapping the onboarding scenario for a clinical revenue-cycle team, a university department, or a branch banking team reskins the module without touching the framework.

Module 2 is the most transferable of the three. A defensive reaction to feedback reads the same in a hospital, a bank, or a school district, so localization here is cosmetic: names, and the nature of the work being discussed.

Module 3 is the richest module to localize and the one I would build first for a specific client. Communication rhythms vary more by sector than anything else in this series. A shift-based clinical team, a distributed knowledge-work team, and a committee-driven university department each need a genuinely different plan, and that contrast is worth showcasing rather than smoothing over.

Design rationale summary

Module 1: Setting Expectations. This module targets the most common and least visible failure of a new manager's first weeks: expectations that feel clear in the manager's head but were never made explicit. I wrote the terminal objective at Bloom's Apply level and in Mager's ABCD format, because the goal isn't for learners to recite what a good expectation looks like; it's for them to conduct the actual conversation and produce measurable, mutually confirmed expectations against a checklist. The two branching scenarios carry the instructional load: the first asks learners to build a workable expectation for an ongoing responsibility, and the second puts them in a pushback conversation where the tempting wrong moves (capitulating or going rigid) are the ones real managers reach for under discomfort.

Module 2: Feedback Conversations. The gap statement identified avoided and softened feedback as the failure that lets small performance issues entrench, so this module trains delivery, not recognition. I structured the objective around Situation-Behavior-Impact and pitched it toward Bloom's Create: learners construct and deliver a feedback script judged against a quality rubric, rather than merely identifying good feedback when they see it. The first scenario trains the distinction that makes or breaks a feedback conversation: naming a behavior versus delivering a verdict on someone's character. The second models what happens when feedback meets defensiveness. The durable skill there is holding two things at once, the standard and the person's real concern, which comes down to saying "and" rather than "but."

Module 3: Team Communication. This module sits at the top of the series' difficulty arc because the underlying skill is the hardest: not a single well-run conversation but an ongoing system that keeps a team informed and trusting. I wrote the terminal objective at Bloom's Create (learners design a 90-day communication plan matching channels and rhythms to purposes) because managing communication is fundamentally a design problem, not a scripting one. The two scenarios split that skill into its failure-prone halves: choosing the right channel for a sensitive matter, where the instinct to fire off a chat message quietly does real damage, and repairing trust after a breakdown, where the durable move is to fix both the immediate rupture and the decision-making habit that caused it.

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